ACTIVITY 15

Play a game with a partner.

1 Each of you should choose two characters from different well known TV drama series.

2 Think of three facts about each character and give them one by one to your partner as clues, starting with the most difficult to guess. Award 5 points for guessing with just one clue, 3 for two guesses and 1 for three guesses. (You could make this a whole-class activity with rounds and a final winner.)

Analysing character can revolve around several important areas:

- The character's role in the drama
- Their relationship with other characters
- The ways that the actor brings the character to life:
  - use of voice or accent
  - movement and gesture
  - emotional power to engage with the audience.





14 Characters in soap operas become very familiar to their audiences

KEY TERMS

Central protagonists key characters around whom the text and narrative are centred

Stereotypical grouping people together according to simple shared characteristics, without allowing for any individual uniqueness

The audience can usually spot two main types of characters in a drama – those who are less important and are there for 'padding', and those around whom the main narrative(s) centre. For example, in a medical drama the people who have accidents are only shown for some of one programme, whereas the hospital staff are seen week after week. The less important characters are less developed and often more **stereotypical** than the main characters or **central protagonists** (**14**).

ACTIVITY 16

Watch a clip from any TV drama. Decide which are the less important characters and which are the central protagonists. What information did you use to help you decide?

Setting

The location of a TV drama is important in establishing a sense of a real place where the story can exist. Many regional features may well appear, such as landmarks and the local accent, dress and customs of those who live there.

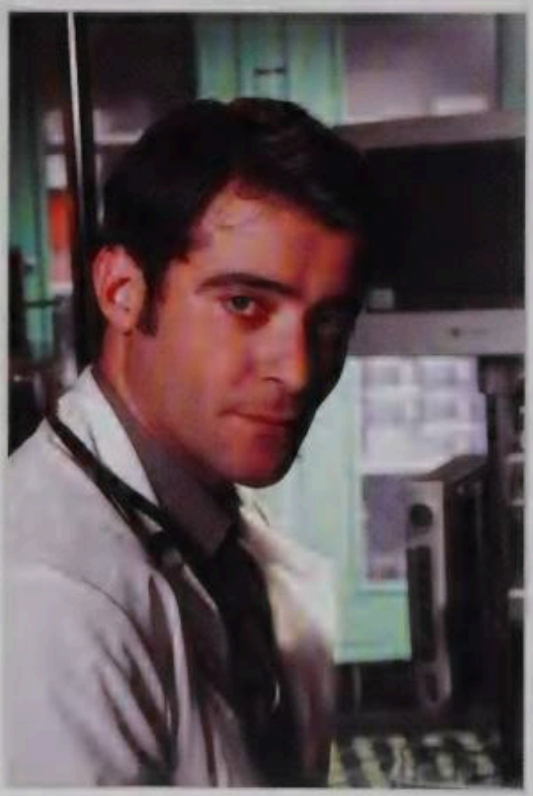
These features are included to encourage as strong a sense of engagement with the world of the drama, the characters and their lives as possible. Audiences continued to remember Dirty Den, for example, long after his exit from Albert Square because he was so perfectly set into the location and community of *EastEnders* – this also explains why his return was so well publicised. Fans of TV drama sometimes write in to their favourite characters, forgetting that they are played by actors and do not really exist.

One of the most important features of most television dramas is that they create believable or realistic worlds that audiences can watch and feel convinced by. The following case study will help you focus on just one sub-genre – the medical drama – in order to see how producers go about creating those real worlds.

Case study – medical drama

Medical drama is one of the most popular sub-genres of drama on television. It has its own set of conventions, all of which are designed to make viewers believe that the world of the programme really exists.

Medical drama developed from soap opera – serialised drama on radio and television paid for by washing powder manufacturers. It became clear that the audience for daytime soap operas – housewives at home during the day – also enjoyed dramas based in hospital wards and in doctors' surgeries. Before long soap operas appeared during peak-time viewing. Early examples included *Doctor Finlay's Casebook* and *Doctor Kildare*, which were extremely popular in the 1960s.



15 *ER* is a popular medical drama from the USA

Two of the most popular UK medical dramas of recent years are *Casualty*, which began broadcasting on BBC1 in 1985, and its sister programme *Holby City*, also on BBC1, which began life in 1999. *ER*, on Channel 4, is an American medical drama set in Chicago that also has a large following (see **15**).

ACTIVITY 17

Find out more about medical drama in the UK and in the USA. Use a search engine to research on the Internet the most important medical drama programmes and how they have developed. For each series try to find out:

- when the series started
- where it is set
- any ways in which the series has changed over the years.

KEY TERMS

Cross-plot a way of tracking different storylines through a single episode of a TV drama series

Multi-stranded narrative when a television drama not only follows more than one storyline but also interweaves them

Medical dramas often have a **multi-stranded narrative** where there is more than one story in one episode. The most important narrative in any particular episode usually acts as a cliff-hanger to keep audiences interested until the next episode. These narratives are interwoven or mixed together, and it is possible to draw a special chart called a **cross-plot** to make it easier to analyse how the narrative works.

ACTIVITY 18

Use the chart below to create a cross-plot of an episode of your favourite medical drama. The cross-plot in **16** from an episode of a fictitious medical drama has been started to help you.

1 Start by watching the episode and making a list of all the scenes featured and what happens in them. There could well be more than fifteen.

2 Draw a chart like the one in **16**, and write the characters in the main storylines in the boxes on the left. Make a column for each scene.

3 Using your scene list, put an X in each scene where a character from a particular storyline is featured.

4 If a character appears briefly in another scene/storyline, put a small asterisk (*) in that scene.

***Medics*, 17 August 2004**	**scene 1**	**scene 2**	**scene 3**	**scene 4**	**scene 5**	**scene 6**	**scene 7**	**scene 8**	**scene 9**	**scene 10**	**scene 11**	**scene 12**	**scene 13**	**scene 14**	**scene 15**
STORY 1 – Mr Singh Heart transplant	X		X			X		X		X	X	X		X	
STORY 2 – Mrs Spicer Heart harvest	X		X		X		X		X		X	X			X
STORY 3 – Paula The new job		X	*	X	*		*		*		X		X		

16 Cross-plot of an episode of a medical drama

Now that you have created your own cross-plot, you can analyse the ways in which the different storylines are interwoven, and how certain storylines dominate the episode. What do you notice about the pace and frequency of scenes towards the end of the episode? Which storyline does the episode end on?

Other important characteristics to look for when analysing medical drama are:

- a strong sense of realism in the setting and atmosphere
- a difference between the stable, regular characters (usually the doctors, nurses and medical personnel) and the visiting characters who are just there for one or two episodes (usually the patients and their relatives)
- sets that are carefully planned to be as believable as possible; décor, props and the behaviour of people in them are designed to convince the audience that they really do exist. Programme-makers usually have real doctors giving advice on the correct language and equipment to use in medical situations
- episodes that usually follow the pattern of a normal day, i.e. morning until night.

ACTIVITY 19

Watch two different medical dramas. Try to identify as many of the above characteristics as you can.

ACTIVITY 20 EXTENSION

Choose one popular British medical drama and one American one. Compare the storylines, characters and settings. Try to think of reasons to explain the main differences between them.

Medical cross-genres

You have already learned about the medical drama as a sub-genre of TV drama, but there are many cross-genres that have become very popular too. Examples include detective medical dramas such as *Diagnosis Murder*, crime thriller medical dramas such as *Silent Witness*, spoof medical dramas such as *Scrubs* and soap-style medical dramas such as *Doctors*.

ACTIVITY 21

1 Find two pages from TV listings magazines that have features on two different types of medical dramas.

2 Stick them onto A3 paper and label them, pointing out all their typical features and the ways the dramas have been made to seem interesting and appealing, e.g. by focusing on the dramatic developments in the storyline of a regular character to encourage viewers to want to see what happens to them.

Situation comedy

Types of humour

Think about your favourite sitcoms – you may enjoy them for all sorts of reasons, but above all it is because they make you laugh. Often the humour is based on visual comedy, like the classic 'pratfall' of the silent film era where the characters fall on their bottoms or slip on banana skins. This humour needs no explanation and works across different cultures because no language is involved.

Sometimes the humour is caused by the relationship between the characters – naughty children exasperating fathers or older brothers playing tricks on younger siblings. This comedy arises from the situation people are in, and is therefore called *situation comedy* or *sitcom*.

Humour also reflects people's beliefs and personalities, so they may prefer some programmes to others depending on their own experience.

ACTIVITY 22

Draw a table like the one below. Think of four more examples to add to the list, using your own experience of what you find funny.

Visual comedy	Comedy situations
Dad falls off ladder when son opens upstairs window.	*Naughty son hides school report but 'good' daughter finds it and blackmails him.*

Sitcoms and the family

The sitcom is now a television genre, but it began its life on radio in half-hour shows presenting characters in a common environment such as the workplace or the family home.

Family life has been a subject of sitcom since the early days of television. There have been many types of family represented. In the USA in the 1950s a hit sitcom *I Love Lucy* (**17**) brought to the screens a lovable yet hopeless housewife who was always getting into tricky situations that usually involved misunderstandings with her husband Ricky. The network did something unusual for the times with this live television show – they recorded it. This meant that they could show repeats and attract new audiences as the years went by.



17 Lucy and Ricky from *I Love Lucy*